
SPOTTING BIG TRENDS

Deep Research Handout

Global megatrends, subrends, signals, and worksheets (2026-2035)

Prepared for classroom use

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Note: Educational material synthesized from public sources. Not investment advice.



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How to use this handout

This handout is designed to help you move from broad megatrends to actionable trend theses. Use it as a repeatable workflow for research, discussion, and idea generation.

A simple classroom loop

- Map: megatrend -> subtrend -> local effects (customers, regulation, infrastructure).
- Instrument: choose 3-7 measurable signals to track each subtrend.
- Stress-test: write disconfirming evidence and scenario signposts.
- Translate: derive opportunity patterns (who pays, what changes, what breaks).

The meta-insight for 2026-2035

Track the new scarcity stack: electricity + compute + critical minerals + trust.

Most second-order opportunities sit at the intersections of these constraints.

Executive summary

Four megatrends remain the best high-level map, but the most important dynamics are their interactions. Fragmentation changes the global operating model; climate transition adds physical and financial constraints; technology moves from tools to autonomy; demographics reshape labor, care, and trust.

What is structurally different now

- Globalization is shifting from optimize to secure + comply + duplicate.
- Resilience (energy, supply chains, infrastructure) becomes a core cost category.
- AI value shifts from model quality alone to workflow integration, governance, and reliability.
- Aging societies face labor scarcity, while youth-bulge regions face a jobs race.

10 cross-trend intersections to watch

Intersection	What changes
AI x Energy	Compute advantage becomes power advantage (grids, siting, cooling).
Climate x Insurance	Risk repricing changes real estate and municipal finance.
Minerals x Geopolitics	Refining and processing chokepoints shape alliances and industrial policy.
Fragmentation x Standards	Compliance becomes a product feature (AI, ESG, supply chain).
Aging x Automation	Workforce augmentation shifts from optional to necessary.
Youth bulge x Platforms	Skills-to-income rails and SME enablement become stability tools.
AI x Trust	Provenance and verification become critical infrastructure online.
Circularity x Regulation	Repairability and durability become market access conditions.
De-risking x Costs	Resilience premium increases demand for efficiency and visibility tools.
Governance erosion x Private rules	Mini-lateral agreements and private standards proliferate.

Megatrend 1: Geopolitical and economic fragmentation

The global economy is moving from a single, integrated operating environment to multiple rule-sets, regional supply networks, and heavier use of economic tools as strategic instruments (export controls, subsidies, screening, standards).

Key subtrends

- Transactional middle powers: issue-by-issue coalitions and shifting alignments.
- Supply chain regionalization: near-shoring, friend-shoring, and resilience premiums.
- Weaponized interdependence: export controls, sanctions, and investment screening as design constraints.
- Industrial policy competition: subsidies and local content rules reshape capex decisions.
- Governance workarounds: mini-lateral deals and private standards fill multilateral gaps.

Signals to track

- Trade-restrictive coverage in monitoring reports and frequency of new measures.
- Export control rule updates, controlled categories, and licensing timelines.
- Greenfield FDI announcements and capacity builds in connector geographies.
- Standards divergence across blocs (AI, cybersecurity, ESG, product safety).

Opportunity patterns

- Compliance-native products: audit trails, geo-fenced features, and modular architectures.
- Supply chain visibility: provenance, tier-n mapping, and disruption simulations.
- Industrial policy translation: tooling that helps firms qualify, report, and audit programs.

Discussion prompts

- Where in your industry does compliance become a product feature rather than a back-office cost?
- If supply chains must be duplicated, what becomes the scarcest input: parts, permits, capital, or talent?
- What would it take to provide credible provenance for a product at tier-n (not just tier-1)?

Megatrend 2: Climate emergency and the great transition

The transition is not only decarbonization. It is also adaptation, critical minerals security, and a financial system repricing risk through disclosure, insurance, and capital costs.

Key subtrends

- Adaptation economy: resilience capex grows (heat, flood, water, grid hardening).
- New geopolitics of minerals: mining, refining, and recycling capacity become strategic.
- Climate risk in finance: disclosures, transition plans, and liability pressures.
- Circular economy imperative: repairability, durability, and product passports.

Signals to track

- Adaptation finance gap measures and growth in resilience spending.
- Insurance pricing and coverage availability in high-risk regions.
- Critical mineral concentration metrics and export restrictions.
- Repairability and durability requirements in major markets.

Opportunity patterns

- Resilience-as-a-service: engineering + monitoring + finance/insurance partnerships.
- Traceability and material intelligence: compliance plus supply security.
- Distributed repair infrastructure: diagnostics, parts logistics, and certified networks.

Discussion prompts

- Which climate risks are becoming price signals (insurance, capital costs) in your region?
- What assets are at risk of becoming stranded - and what replaces them (retrofit, repurpose, retire)?
- Where could circularity (repair, reuse, recycling) reduce dependence on fragile supply chains?

Megatrend 3: Accelerating technological disruption

Technology is shifting from tools to autonomy. Agentic AI, robotics, biotech, and spatial computing converge, while physical constraints (electricity, chips, cooling) and governance constraints (regulation, trust) shape adoption.

Key subtrends

- Agentic AI: systems that plan and act across workflows, not just generate content.
- Compute and infrastructure arms race: chips, data centers, power, and grid queues.
- AI governance and safety: evaluation, monitoring, and auditability become mandatory in many contexts.
- Bio-digital convergence: AI-accelerated R&D, lab automation, and personalized medicine.
- Spatial computing and digital twins: simulation and training become routine in regulated industries.

Signals to track

- Enterprise spend shifts from pilots to governed, production-grade agent platforms.
- Data center power demand growth, interconnection delays, and siting constraints.
- Regulatory milestones (phased AI rules, enforcement guidance, audits).
- R&D; cycle time reductions in drug discovery and lab automation adoption.

Opportunity patterns

- Agent reliability infrastructure: sandboxing, permissions, rollback, simulation testing.
- Energy-aware compute: scheduling and optimization around grid and carbon constraints.
- Authenticity and provenance: verification for synthetic media and digital commerce.

Discussion prompts

- What workflow would you automate first if agents were reliable and permissioned - and what stops you today?
- Where does electricity availability (not model quality) become the binding constraint for AI adoption?
- Which decisions in your domain require provable outputs (audit trails, citations, reproducibility)?

Megatrend 4: Demographic divergence and societal shifts

The world is splitting into aging, low-fertility regions with labor scarcity and youth-bulge regions where job creation determines stability. In parallel, trust is fragmenting and well-being is becoming an economic variable.

Key subtrends

- Silver economy: healthcare, care coordination, accessible housing, and longevity services.
- Labor shortage era: productivity tools and automation to augment scarce workers.
- Youth bulge and jobs race: skills-to-income pathways, fintech, and SME enablement.
- Crisis of trust and insularity: smaller trusted communities, creator influence, verification demand.
- Redefinition of well-being: evidence-based mental health, chronic care prevention, and financial resilience.

Signals to track

- Vacancy rates in care, health, skilled trades, and education.
- Policy shifts on retirement, migration, and caregiver support.
- Youth NEET rates and formal job creation pace by region.
- Trust metrics and adoption of verification tools in media/commerce.

Opportunity patterns

- Care infrastructure platforms: scheduling, documentation automation, remote monitoring.
- Skills-to-income rails: credentialing linked to verified work outcomes.
- Trust brokers: reputation, dispute resolution, and authenticity tooling for communities.

Discussion prompts

- Which services break first under labor scarcity - and what is the minimum viable automation?
- Where can better care coordination reduce total cost (and caregiver burnout) without lowering quality?
- What would it take to make trust portable across platforms (identity, reputation, verification)?

Scenario set (2030-2035)

Use these four teachable scenarios as a discussion tool. Each scenario is a combination of (A) cooperation vs fragmentation and (B) fast vs slow/chaotic transition (energy + AI governance).

Scenario	Description	What to look for (signposts)
Green Tech Cold War	Fragmentation + fast buildout. Blocs race to secure minerals, chips, and grid capacity. Rules diverge; compliance becomes a moat.	Export control expansion; mineral stockpiling; subsidy escalation; standards divergence.
Cooperative Acceleration	Cooperation + fast buildout. Some standard harmonization and faster capital formation for grids and adaptation.	Interoperability standards; aligned disclosure baselines; more joint infrastructure financing.
Fortress Patchworks	Fragmentation + slow transition. Underinvestment in grids and adaptation; higher disaster losses; trust fractures.	Widening adaptation finance gaps; insurance withdrawals; rising polarization and misinformation.
Resilience Pragmatism	Mixed cooperation + uneven but practical transition. Local resilience grows fastest; repair and circularity expand.	Repair obligations expand; resilience procurement grows; regional growth poles around power availability.

How to use scenarios

- Pick one scenario and rewrite your trend thesis: what accelerates, what stalls, what breaks?
- List 3 signposts you could observe within 6-12 months that would indicate you are moving into that world.
- Identify one strategy that is robust across all four scenarios (a no-regrets move).

Signal dashboard: 25 indicators to track

Assign each student team one megatrend and require: (1) five signals, (2) a target range or threshold, (3) a disconfirming signal, and (4) a monthly update cadence.

Fragmentation

- Trade-restrictive coverage and new measures frequency (WTO monitoring).
- Export control updates and entity list changes (semiconductors, compute, tools).
- FDI shifts into connector geographies (manufacturing, logistics, energy).
- Dispute settlement reform progress vs stagnation (rule enforcement).
- Industrial policy awards and local content rules by sector.

Climate transition

- Adaptation finance gap and resilience procurement growth.
- Insured catastrophe losses and premium / coverage availability changes.
- Critical mineral concentration, price volatility, and export restrictions.
- Grid interconnection queue length and transmission buildout pace.
- Repairability and durability regulations (application dates and scope).

Tech disruption

- Enterprise move from chat pilots to governed agent platforms.
- Data center power demand growth and siting constraints.
- AI regulation milestones, standards, and enforcement actions.
- Cyber incidents in critical infrastructure and supply chain security posture.
- R&D; cycle time reductions in bio/AI and lab automation adoption.

Demographics and society

- Old-age dependency ratios and labor participation trends.
- Vacancy rates in care/health/skilled trades and wage pressure.
- Youth NEET rates, formal job creation, and SME formation rates.
- Trust and insularity metrics; verification tool adoption.
- Wellness economy spending mix and evidence-based outcomes adoption.

Worksheets

Use the following pages as printable templates. Encourage students to write with clear assumptions and measurable signals.

Worksheet 1: Trend card

Trend name	
Megatrend anchor	
Subtrend definition (1-2 sentences)	
Why now? (drivers and constraints)	
Who feels it first? (customer segments / geographies)	
3-7 measurable signals (with data sources)	
Disconfirming evidence (what would prove this wrong?)	
Second-order effects (2-3)	
Opportunity patterns (business models)	
Risks and ethical concerns	

Worksheet 2: Monitoring plan

Fill this in for one trend thesis and update monthly.

Signal	Metric / threshold	Data source	Current reading	Interpretation

Selected sources (for further reading)

This handout synthesizes publicly available research and institutional reporting. Titles below are provided to support deeper reading and classroom citation.

- 1 IPCC (2023). Climate Change 2023: AR6 Synthesis Report - Summary for Policymakers.
- 2 UNEP (2025). Adaptation Gap Report 2025: Running on Empty.
- 3 International Energy Agency (2024/2025). AI, data centres, and electricity demand analysis (news + related reports).
- 4 International Energy Agency (2025). Global Critical Minerals Outlook 2025.
- 5 European Court of Auditors (2026). Critical raw materials for the energy transition (Special Report 2026/04).
- 6 European Commission (CSRD). Corporate Sustainability Reporting Directive overview and timing (first reporting for FY2024 published in 2025).
- 7 IFRS / ISSB (2023). IFRS S2 Climate-related Disclosures (effective for periods beginning on/after 1 Jan 2024; jurisdictional adoption varies).
- 8 European Commission (2024). Directive (EU) 2024/1799 on common rules promoting the repair of goods (apply from 31 Jul 2026).
- 9 WTO (2024-2025). Trade monitoring and trade measure overviews (G20 and WTO members).
- 10 Gartner (2024). Top 10 Strategic Technology Trends for 2025 (press release).
- 11 WHO (2025). Ageing and health (factsheet).
- 12 OECD (2025). OECD Employment Outlook 2025: From job shortage to labour shortage.
- 13 Edelman (2026). Edelman Trust Barometer 2026 (insularity replaces grievance).
- 14 Global Wellness Institute (2024). 2024 Global Wellness Economy Monitor.
- 15 McKinsey Global Institute (2025). The great trade rearrangement (rearrangement ratio and trade geometry).
- 16 IMF (2023-2024). Research on geoeconomic fragmentation and the costs of de-risking (reshoring and friend-shoring).
- 17 US Department of Commerce, Bureau of Industry and Security (BIS) (2022-2024). Export controls on advanced computing and semiconductor manufacturing items.
- 18 Swiss Re Institute (2024). Insured losses from natural catastrophes surpass \$100B for multiple consecutive years (press release).
- 19 EU AI Act Service Desk (2024-2027). Timeline for progressive application of the EU AI Act.